

Sin, Spiritual Death, the Soul, and Final Judgment

A Hebrew–Greek Lexical and Theological Study of *Nephesh*, *Psychē*, *Sheol*, *Hades*, *Gehenna*, *Aiōn*, and the “Second Death”

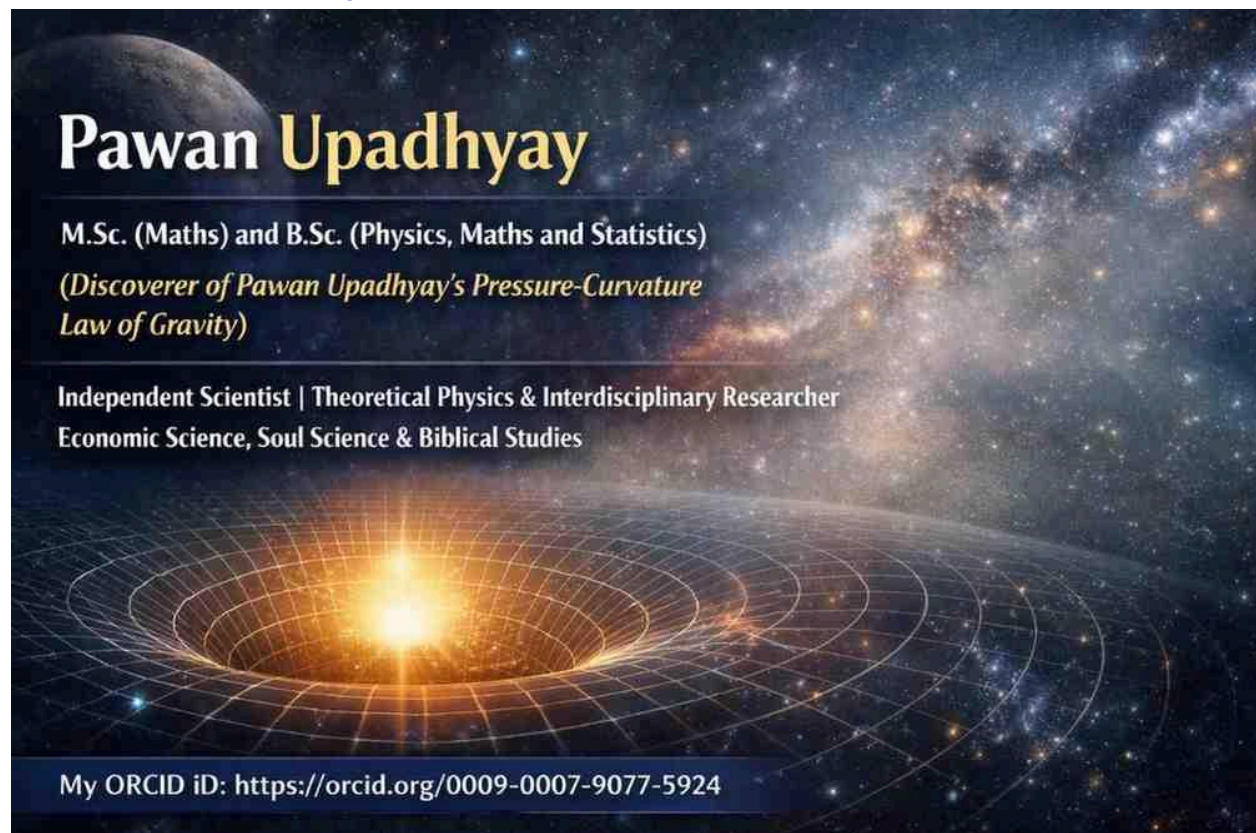
Author: Pawan Upadhyay

Affiliation: Independent Researcher and Independent Scientist

Email: pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com

2nd Email: pawankanyakubj@gmail.com

ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924>



Abstract

This research paper investigates the biblical relationship between sin, spiritual death, the human soul, physical death, the realm of the dead, judgment, and the final punishment described in Scripture. Particular attention is given to the Hebrew terms **נֶפֶשׁ** (*nephesh*, Strong's H5315) and **שְׁאוֹל** (*Sheol*, H7585), together with the Greek terms **ψυχή** (*psychē*, G5590), **ᾍδης** (*Hades*, G86), **γέεννα** (*Gehenna*, G1067), **θάνατος** (*thanatos*, G2288), **αἰών** (*aiōn*, G165), **αἰώνιος** (*aiōnios*, G166), **κόλασις** (*kolasis*, G2851), and **ἀπόλλυμι** (*apollymi*, G622).

The study distinguishes lexical evidence from theological interpretation. The lexical evidence indicates that *nephesh* and *psychē* possess broad semantic ranges that include life, person, self, living being, and soul. Consequently, neither term can be reduced to a single philosophical definition of an inherently immortal soul. Similarly, *Sheol* and *Hades* are associated with the realm or condition of the dead and should not simply be equated with the final lake of fire. *Gehenna* occurs in contexts of divine judgment, while Revelation explicitly identifies the lake of fire with the “second death.”

A major part of the paper concerns **αἰών** (*aiōn*) and **αἰώνιος** (*aiōnios*). This study adopts “**long-age**” as its interpretive translation of *aiōnios* in the principal eschatological passages under investigation. Accordingly, expressions traditionally rendered “eternal fire,” “eternal punishment,” and “eternal life” are examined as “**long-age fire**,” “**long-age punishment**,” and “**long-age life**.” This does not mean that all Greek lexicons agree that *aiōnios* must mean “long-age”; rather, the paper argues that the age-related sense deserves contextual consideration and should not be excluded merely because English translations traditionally use “eternal.”

Matthew 25:46 is given particular attention because the same adjective, *aiōnion*, modifies both punishment and life. The paper argues that this grammatical parallel requires a consistent explanation. The study further considers the concepts of spiritual death, resurrection, immortality, Gehenna, destruction, the lake of fire, and the second death.

The conclusion proposes that sin produces spiritual death by corrupting the moral and spiritual nature of the person and separating the person from God. It further proposes that the biblical vocabulary does not justify treating *nephesh*, *psychē*, *Sheol*, *Hades*, *Gehenna*, and the “second death” as synonymous. Finally, the paper argues that the nature and duration of final punishment should be determined through contextual exegesis of the complete biblical witness rather than through English translation tradition or Strong's-number definitions alone.

Keywords: sin, spiritual death, soul, *nephesh*, *psychē*, *Sheol*, *Hades*, *Gehenna*, *aiōn*, *aiōnios*, long-age, long-age fire, long-age punishment, second death, lake of fire, judgment

1. Introduction

Questions concerning sin, death, the soul, hell, judgment, and immortality occupy a central position in biblical theology. Yet these subjects are frequently discussed using English terminology that does not preserve all of the distinctions present in the Hebrew and Greek Scriptures.

The English word “**hell**” provides one of the clearest examples. Biblical Hebrew and Greek use several terms associated with death and judgment, including *Sheol*, *Hades*, and *Gehenna*. These words are related but should not automatically be regarded as identical.

The same problem occurs with the English word “**soul**.” The Hebrew *nephesh* and Greek *psychē* are commonly translated “soul,” but both words have considerably broader semantic ranges. *Nephesh* can refer to life, a living being, person, self, desire, or soul. *Psychē* can likewise refer to life, person, self, inner being, or soul.

A further linguistic question concerns the Greek adjective αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*, **G166**). English translations traditionally render it “eternal,” “everlasting,” or “forever.” Yet the adjective is related to αἰών (*aiōn*, **G165**), a word that can denote an age, epoch, era, or, in some contexts, perpetuity.

This relationship has generated a long-standing theological debate concerning passages such as:

- Matthew 18:8 — “eternal fire”
- Matthew 25:41 — “eternal fire”
- Matthew 25:46 — “eternal punishment”
- Matthew 25:46 — “eternal life”
- Jude 7 — “eternal fire”

The present study adopts “**long-age**” as a deliberate interpretive translation of *aiōnios* in these passages. The purpose is not to claim that no scholar or lexicon recognizes an eternal sense. Rather, it is to investigate whether the context requires an endless-duration meaning.

2. Research Questions

This paper addresses the following questions:

1. What is the semantic range of *nephesh*?
2. What is the semantic range of *psychē*?
3. What are *Sheol* and *Hades*?
4. How is *Gehenna* different from *Sheol* and *Hades*?
5. What does the Bible mean by spiritual death?
6. What is the “second death”?

7. What is the relationship between *aiōn* and *aiōnios*?
 8. Can *aiōnios* legitimately be interpreted as “long-age” in eschatological passages?
 9. What does “long-age fire” mean?
 10. What does Matthew 25:46 mean under a long-age interpretation?
 11. What role do *kolasis* and *apollymi* play in understanding judgment?
 12. Does biblical vocabulary establish that the soul is inherently immortal?
 13. What theological conclusions can responsibly be drawn from the lexical evidence?
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3. Methodology

The paper uses three distinct levels of analysis.

3.1 Lexical Analysis

The first level asks:

What meanings can the Hebrew or Greek word have?

Strong's numbers are supplied for identification. They are not treated as independent theological authorities.

3.2 Contextual Exegesis

The second level asks:

What does the word mean in the particular biblical passage?

Meaning is determined by grammar, syntax, literary context, immediate context, and broader biblical usage.

3.3 Theological Synthesis

The third level asks:

What theological conclusion follows from the textual evidence?

This distinction is essential.

A lexical possibility is not automatically a theological conclusion.

For example:

Aiōn can mean “age.”

does not automatically prove:

Aiōnios always means “temporary.”

Likewise:

Nephesh can mean “soul.”

does not automatically prove:

every human soul is inherently immortal.

The paper therefore attempts to avoid the **lexical fallacy** of assigning the entire theological meaning of a word to every occurrence.

4. Sin and Spiritual Death

Sin is presented in Scripture not merely as an individual act but as a destructive spiritual condition.

Paul tells the Ephesians:

“You were dead in trespasses and sins.”
— Ephesians 2:1

The people addressed by Paul were physically alive. Therefore, their “death” cannot mean biological death.

It describes a condition of **spiritual death**.

Spiritual death may therefore be defined provisionally as:

A condition of separation from God produced by sin, in which the person’s moral and spiritual life is corrupted.

This understanding is reinforced by Ephesians 2:4–5, where God is said to make those who were dead “alive together with Christ.”

Thus Scripture presents two contrasting conditions:

death in sin

and

life in God.

5. Sin as Moral Corruption

Sin affects more than external conduct.

Jesus says:

“From within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts...”
— Mark 7:21

The biblical “heart” represents the inner center of thought, desire, intention, and moral choice.

Consequently, repeated sin can affect:

- conscience,
- moral judgment,
- desires,
- habits,
- character,
- relationships,
- spiritual perception.

The process can be represented:

Sinful choice

→ **repeated behavior**

→ **habit**

→ **bondage**

→ **moral corruption**

→ **spiritual death**

Jesus describes this enslaving dimension:

“Everyone who commits sin is a slave to sin.”
— John 8:34

This does not mean that repentance is impossible. Rather, it demonstrates the power that habitual sin can acquire over a person.

6. *Nephesh* — נֶפֶשׁ

Strong's: H5315

The Hebrew noun נֶפֶשׁ (*nephesh*) is traditionally translated “soul.”

Its semantic range includes:

- soul,
- life,
- living being,
- person,
- self,
- desire,
- appetite,
- inner life.

The lexical evidence therefore indicates a word considerably broader than the English philosophical concept of “immortal soul.”

6.1 Genesis 2:7

Genesis 2:7 describes humanity becoming a:

“living soul.”

The Hebrew expression is נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה (*nephesh chayyah*).

The text therefore describes the human being as a living *nephesh*.

This is significant.

It does not require the interpretation:

physical body + separately existing soul = human person.

Instead, the human being is described as a living *nephesh*.

6.2 *Nephesh* and Death

Ezekiel 18:20 states:

“The soul that sinneth, it shall die.”

The word translated “soul” is *nephesh*.

This demonstrates that *nephesh* itself cannot simply be defined lexically as “an immortal soul that cannot die.”

Lexical conclusion

Nephesh can mean **person, life, self, living being, desire, or soul**, depending on context.

Theological conclusion

The doctrine of an immortal soul cannot be established from the lexical definition of *nephesh* alone.

7. *Psychē* — ψυχή

Strong's: G5590

The Greek noun ψυχή (*psychē*) is commonly translated “soul.”

Its semantic range includes:

- soul,
- life,
- self,
- person,
- inner being.

7.1 *Psychē* as Life

Mark 8:35 uses *psychē* in the sense of “life”:

“Whoever would save his life will lose it.”

Therefore *psychē* does not mean “immortal soul” in every occurrence.

7.2 Matthew 10:28

Jesus says:

“Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul.”

Here the text distinguishes:

σῶμα (*sōma*) — body

from

ψυχή (*psychē*) — soul.

This is important evidence that *psychē* can refer to an aspect of human existence distinguished from the physical body.

However, the verse does not by itself resolve every question concerning the nature or immortality of the soul.

8. The Soul, Body, Life, and Immortality

The Bible uses several concepts when discussing human existence.

These include:

- body,
- soul,
- spirit,
- life,
- death,
- resurrection,
- immortality.

It is therefore dangerous to reduce biblical anthropology to a single formula.

Paul says:

“This mortal must put on immortality.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:53

This language places immortality within the context of resurrection.

First Timothy 6:16 also describes God as uniquely possessing immortality.

Thus the strongest biblical formulation is not necessarily:

“Every soul possesses independent immortality.”

Instead:

Human existence continues according to God's will and is ultimately transformed through resurrection and divine life.

Whether the soul is inherently immortal remains a theological question requiring broader analysis.

9. Sheol — שְׁאוֹל

Strong's: H7585

Sheol is a major Old Testament term associated with death and the realm or condition of the dead.

It occurs in passages such as:

- Genesis 37:35
- Psalm 6:5
- Psalm 16:10
- Psalm 49:15
- Isaiah 14:9

Sheol should not simply be equated with the final lake of fire.

The Old Testament can use Sheol in relation to the dead generally.

Therefore:

Sheol ≠ automatically final punishment.

This distinction is important because many English readers encounter “hell” where Hebrew actually contains *Sheol*.

10. Hades — ᾍδης

Strong's: G86

Hades is the Greek term associated with the realm of the dead.

The relationship between *Sheol* and *Hades* is particularly visible in Acts 2:27, where Peter quotes Psalm 16.

The Hebrew *Sheol* is represented in the Greek tradition by *Hades*.

Thus:

Sheol → Hades

provides an important conceptual correspondence.

But Hades should not automatically be identified with the final lake of fire.

Revelation 20:13–14 says:

“Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them.”

Then Death and Hades are thrown into the lake of fire.

Therefore:

Hades ≠ lake of fire

at least at the level of the sequence described in Revelation.

11. Gehenna — γέεννα

Strong's: G1067

Gehenna is a distinct Greek term frequently translated “hell.”

It is associated historically with the Valley of Hinnom and appears especially in Jesus' warnings concerning judgment.

Important passages include:

- Matthew 5:22

- Matthew 5:29–30
- Matthew 10:28
- Matthew 18:9
- Mark 9:43–48
- Luke 12:5
- James 3:6

Matthew 10:28 is especially important:

“Fear him who can destroy both soul and body in Gehenna.”

The verse connects:

soul

body

Gehenna

and

destruction.

The verb “destroy” is ἀπόλλυμι (*apollymi*, G622).

Thus a full interpretation of Matthew 10:28 requires examination of both *Gehenna* and *apollymi*.

12. *Thanatos* — θάνατος

Strong's: G2288

Thanatos means **death**.

It can describe physical death, but biblical writers also use death language metaphorically.

Ephesians 2:1 is again central:

“You were dead in trespasses and sins.”

The people were physically alive.

Therefore, this is spiritual death.

We can distinguish:

Physical death

The end of earthly bodily life.

Spiritual death

Alienation from God because of sin.

Second death

The eschatological expression used in Revelation.

These concepts must be distinguished.

13. The “Second Death”

The expression “**second death**” occurs in Revelation.

Greek:

δεύτερος θάνατος (*deuteros thanatos*)

Revelation 20:14 states:

“This is the second death, the lake of fire.”

The Greek text explicitly connects:

second death

with

lake of fire.

Revelation 21:8 uses the same expression.

Therefore:

Lake of fire = second death

is an explicit textual identification.

14. Death and Hades Versus the Second Death

Revelation 20:13–14 gives a significant sequence:

1. Death and Hades contain the dead.
2. Death and Hades give up the dead.
3. Judgment occurs.
4. Death and Hades are thrown into the lake of fire.
5. The lake of fire is identified as the second death.

This sequence demonstrates that:

Hades

and

second death

are not simply identical concepts.

The distinction is important for a theology of final judgment.

15. *Aiōn* — αἰών

Strong's: G165

The Greek noun αἰών (*aiōn*) is central to this research.

Its lexical range includes:

- age,
- era,
- epoch,
- period,
- course,
- world,
- perpetuity,
- eternity in some contexts.

The New Testament uses *aiōn* in expressions such as:

“this age”

and:

“the age to come.”

This eschatological distinction is particularly important.

The biblical writers therefore possessed a clear linguistic category for:

present age

and

coming age.

16. *Aiōnios* — αἰώνιος

Strong's: G166

Aiōnios is the adjective related to *aiōn*.

Many English translations render it:

- eternal,
- everlasting,
- forever.

Strong's resources also record an “age-long” sense and connect the adjective with *aiōn*.

This paper adopts:

LONG-AGE

as the preferred translation in the eschatological passages under investigation.

This is a stated interpretive position.

It is not being presented as though every modern Greek lexicon unanimously defines *aiōnios* as “long-age.”

17. Why This Paper Uses “Long-Age”

The reasoning is cumulative.

First

Aiōn can mean **age**.

Second

Aiōnios is derived from *aiōn*.

Third

The New Testament explicitly speaks of **the age to come**.

Fourth

The judgment passages occur within an eschatological framework.

Fifth

The adjective must be interpreted according to context rather than automatically importing the English philosophical meaning of “eternal.”

Therefore this paper investigates:

long-age fire

rather than assuming:

endless fire.

18. “Long-Age Fire” — Πῦρ Αἰώνιον

The Greek expression commonly translated:

“eternal fire”

is:

πῦρ αἰώνιον

The components are:

πῦρ (*pyr*, G4442)

= fire

αἰώνιον (*aiōnion*, G166)

= long-age, according to the interpretive translation adopted here

Thus:

πῦρ αἰώνιον → long-age fire

The adjective modifies the noun “fire.”

The central question is therefore:

Does *aiōnion* necessarily indicate endless duration, or can it describe fire associated with a particular divine age?

This paper argues that the latter possibility deserves serious consideration.

19. Matthew 18:8 — Long-Age Fire

Matthew 18:8 contains:

τὸ πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον

Traditionally:

“the eternal fire.”

Under the present study's translation:

“the long-age fire.”

The context concerns severe divine judgment.

The use of *aiōnios* does not itself provide a complete metaphysical description of the fire.

The interpreter must determine:

- what age is being referenced,

- what the fire accomplishes,
 - how it relates to judgment,
 - and whether Scripture describes a state beyond that judgment.
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20. Matthew 25:41 — Long-Age Fire

Matthew 25:41 contains:

τὸ πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον

Again, the traditional translation is:

“the eternal fire.”

This paper translates:

“the long-age fire.”

The expression occurs within an eschatological judgment scene.

The fire is associated with punishment and divine judgment.

The long-age interpretation therefore understands the phrase as referring to the **fire of the coming judgment age**, without automatically deciding that its duration is metaphysically infinite.

21. Matthew 25:46 — Long-Age Punishment and Long-Age Life

Matthew 25:46 is the most important passage for this thesis.

Greek:

καὶ ἀπελεύσονται οὗτοι εἰς κόλασιν αἰώνιον, οἱ δὲ δίκαιοι εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον.

Under the present translation:

“And these shall go away into long-age punishment, but the righteous into long-age life.”

The Greek contains the same adjective twice:

κόλασιν αἰώνιον

→ long-age punishment

ζωὴν αἰώνιον

→ long-age life

The same form of *aiōnios* modifies both nouns.

22. The Grammatical Parallel

The parallel structure is:

κόλασιν αἰώνιον

and

ζωὴν αἰώνιον

This is significant.

An interpretation cannot simply claim:

Aiōnios means “temporary” when describing punishment but “endless” when describing life.

Such a position would require additional grammatical and theological explanation.

The long-age interpretation instead maintains the same basic sense:

long-age punishment

and

long-age life.

Both belong to the eschatological framework of the age to come.

23. Long-Age Life

Under this study's translation:

ζωὴ αἰώνιος

becomes:

long-age life.

This does not necessarily mean:

“life that ends immediately when the age ends.”

Nor does the phrase by itself necessarily establish:

“life that is philosophically incapable of ending.”

Rather, the adjective identifies the life with the **age to come**.

The ultimate question of whether this life continues beyond the age must be answered through the wider biblical teaching concerning resurrection and immortality.

24. Matthew 25:46 and the Traditional Interpretation

The traditional interpretation understands:

aiōnios punishment = eternal punishment

and:

aiōnios life = eternal life.

This interpretation has substantial historical and theological support.

The present study does not deny that.

Instead, it asks:

Must the Greek adjective necessarily carry the same concept as the English philosophical term “eternal” in this passage?

The long-age thesis answers:

Not necessarily.

The adjective may identify the realities as belonging to the coming age.

25. The Strongest Objection

The strongest objection is the parallelism itself.

If *aiōnios* means “long-age” for punishment, the same adjective means “long-age” for life.

The response is that this is precisely what the paper proposes.

Both are **age-related realities**.

The distinction between their ultimate destinies is established by their nouns:

punishment

versus

life.

The adjective does not need to perform the entire theological function of the phrase.

26. *Kolasis* — κόλασις

Strong's: G2851

Kolasis is generally associated with:

- punishment,
- penalty,
- punitive consequence.

The present study therefore translates:

κόλασις αἰώνιος

as:

long-age punishment.

The paper does not rely upon an etymological argument that *kolasis* must mean “corrective punishment.”

That would be insufficient.

The contextual meaning must be established from actual Greek usage.

The essential argument is instead:

If *aiōnios* is understood as long-age, then *kolasis aiōnios* may be rendered “long-age punishment.”

27. *Apollymi* — ἀπόλλυμι

Strong's: G622

Apollymi has a broad semantic range including:

- destroy,
- perish,
- lose,
- ruin,
- cause to perish.

Matthew 10:28 uses the word in the context of Gehenna:

“who can destroy both soul and body in Gehenna.”

This passage is significant for discussions of annihilation, destruction, and final punishment.

However, one should not assume that *apollymi* always means absolute annihilation.

Its meaning depends upon context.

Therefore:

The word supports a theology of destruction/perishing as a biblical concept, but the word alone does not settle the entire doctrine of final punishment.

28. Long-Age Fire and Destruction

The relationship between *aiōnios* and *apollymi* is important.

Matthew 10:28 describes destruction in Gehenna.

Matthew 25 describes long-age fire and punishment.

Revelation describes the lake of fire as the second death.

These passages should be studied together.

The theological question becomes:

Is the final judgment an endlessly continuing conscious process, an age-long punishment leading to destruction, or another condition?

The lexical evidence alone does not answer this question completely.

29. Unquenchable Fire

Another expression requiring investigation is:

“unquenchable fire.”

The adjective ἄσβεστος (*asbestos*, **G762**) means “unquenchable” or “not extinguished.”

An important exegetical question is:

Does “unquenchable” mean that the fire burns forever, or that no one can extinguish it before it accomplishes its purpose?

The biblical use of fire imagery must therefore be examined contextually.

The expression itself establishes the fire's **unquenchable character**, but the exact duration and result require further analysis.

30. Eternal Fire and Completed Judgment

A fire can be called “unquenchable” because humans cannot stop it, while its ultimate effect may still be complete.

This distinction appears in biblical judgment imagery.

The question is therefore not simply:

“Does the fire burn forever?”

but:

“What does the fire accomplish, and when is its judgment complete?”

This distinction becomes important when comparing:

- fire,
 - destruction,
 - death,
 - punishment,
 - resurrection,
 - and the second death.
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31. Jude 7

Jude 7 describes Sodom and Gomorrah as examples of judgment and refers to:

“the punishment of eternal fire.”

Under the present study's interpretive framework:

“the punishment of long-age fire.”

The passage is significant because the judgment of Sodom is used as an example.

The theological question is whether “eternal” describes the **ongoing burning process** or the **age-related character and significance of the judgment**.

The text therefore deserves comparison with the Old Testament account of Sodom's destruction.

32. Sodom and the Fire of Judgment

Genesis 19 describes the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah.

The physical destruction is presented as a historical event.

Jude later uses the event as an example of divine judgment.

This creates an important exegetical question:

If Jude calls the judgment “long-age fire,” is he necessarily describing a fire that continues physically burning today?

The answer appears to require a distinction between:

the historical event

and

its eschatological significance as an example of judgment.

This supports the need for contextual analysis of judgment language.

33. The “Long-Age” Principle

The central linguistic principle of this study can now be stated:

An age-related adjective does not necessarily function as a mathematical statement specifying infinite duration.

This does not prove that *aiōnios* always means finite duration.

Rather, it means that the interpreter must ask:

1. What age?
2. What quality characterizes that age?
3. What noun is being modified?
4. What is the literary context?
5. Does the passage itself specify what happens afterward?

These questions are especially important for eschatological passages.

34. The Age to Come

Jesus' teachings repeatedly distinguish between:

this age

and

the age to come.

This provides an important framework for interpreting *aiōnios*.

If “long-age” life belongs to the age to come, then it represents the life associated with God's future kingdom.

Likewise, long-age punishment can describe judgment associated with that same eschatological order.

The phrase therefore has a theological dimension beyond mere chronological duration.

35. Long-Age Life and Resurrection

Paul's resurrection theology is essential.

First Corinthians 15 describes resurrection as a transformation from mortality to immortality.

This suggests that the ultimate Christian hope is not merely survival of a disembodied soul.

It is:

resurrection and transformation.

Thus “long-age life” should be understood within the broader biblical doctrine of resurrection.

The righteous receive life in the age to come.

Whether that life is ultimately endless is a further theological conclusion supported by additional biblical passages.

36. The Immortal Soul Question

The thesis that the soul is “unborn and immortal” must be treated separately from the *aiōnios* study.

The lexical evidence demonstrates:

nephesh

→ soul, person, life, self

psychē

→ soul, life, person, self.

Neither word means:

“unborn immortal soul”

as a complete lexical definition.

The doctrine must therefore be developed through:

- creation,
- consciousness,
- death,
- resurrection,
- immortality,
- judgment,
- and God's sustaining power.

37. The Lucifer Question

The traditional Christian concept of Lucifer concerns a heavenly being who fell from an exalted position.

Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 have historically been associated with this doctrine.

However, a research paper must distinguish:

Direct textual meaning

Isaiah 14 addresses the king of Babylon.

Ezekiel 28 addresses the king of Tyre.

Traditional theological interpretation

Later Christian interpretation has seen these passages as reflecting or typologically describing Satan's fall.

The latter should not be presented as though it were the only possible historical interpretation of the passages.

38. Theological Relevance of the Fall

The fall of an exalted being is relevant to this study because it demonstrates an important theological concept:

Exalted status does not automatically imply unchangeable status.

This can be illustrated through the biblical tradition concerning angels who sinned.

Jude 6 speaks of angels who:

“did not keep their own domain.”

Second Peter 2:4 likewise speaks of angels who sinned and were kept for judgment.

Therefore, Scripture contains examples of beings possessing an elevated status who subsequently experience judgment.

This supports the conceptual possibility of an age-related condition followed by transition.

It does not, however, prove the lexical meaning of *aiōnios*.

39. Lexical Evidence Versus Theological Conclusion

This distinction is fundamental.

Lexical evidence establishes:

Nephesh

→ soul, life, person, self

Psychē

→ soul, life, self, person

Sheol

→ realm/condition of the dead

Hades

→ realm/condition of the dead

Gehenna

→ terminology associated with judgment

Aiōn

→ age, epoch, era, and broader senses

Aiōnios

→ adjective related to *aiōn*, with age-related and, in many lexicons, eternal/everlasting senses

Kolasis

→ punishment/penalty

Apollymi

→ destroy/perish/lose/ruin

Theology concludes:

- sin causes spiritual death;
- judgment follows death;
- resurrection is central;
- Hades is distinguishable from the lake of fire;
- the lake of fire is the second death;
- “long-age” is a possible interpretation of *aiōnios* in judgment passages;

- the ultimate duration of punishment requires broader contextual analysis.
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40. Major Interpretations of Final Punishment

Christian theology has historically developed several major interpretations.

40.1 Eternal Conscious Punishment

This view understands final punishment as conscious and without end.

Its principal arguments include:

- the traditional translation “eternal punishment”;
- the parallelism of Matthew 25:46;
- the use of *aiōnios* in other contexts;
- passages concerning ongoing judgment.

40.2 Conditional Immortality / Annihilation

This view argues that immortality is a gift given to the redeemed and that the wicked ultimately perish or are destroyed.

Its principal arguments include:

- “destroy” language;
- “perish” language;
- the second death;
- the contrast between life and death.

40.3 Age-Long Punishment

The present study investigates a third interpretation:

Final punishment is described with *aiōnios*, which is interpreted as long-age, meaning punishment associated with or extending through the coming age.

This view does not necessarily determine what occurs after the age.

It therefore requires further theological investigation.

41. The Strength of the Long-Age Interpretation

The principal strengths are:

1. *Aiōn* explicitly means “age” in many contexts.
 2. The New Testament explicitly speaks about the coming age.
 3. *Aiōnios* is linguistically related to *aiōn*.
 4. The same adjective occurs in both Matthew 25:46 phrases.
 5. “Long-age” avoids assuming the conclusion through the English word “eternal.”
 6. The interpretation allows the eschatological context to determine meaning.
-

42. The Weaknesses and Challenges

A scholarly treatment must acknowledge difficulties.

1. *Aiōnios* can mean “eternal” or “everlasting” in many lexicons.

Strong's resources themselves list eternal/everlasting senses.

2. Matthew 25:46 is grammatically parallel.

The same adjective modifies punishment and life.

3. *Aiōn* itself can also have meanings extending beyond a finite age.

Strong's resources list both age and perpetuity.

4. The long-age interpretation does not automatically prove temporary punishment.

Further eschatological arguments are required.

These challenges do not invalidate the thesis, but they mean that the argument must remain exegetically careful.

43. Why Translation Matters

Translation is not merely a linguistic exercise.

When *aiōnios* is translated:

“eternal”

the reader may naturally understand:

endless duration.

When it is translated:

“long-age”

the reader is invited to investigate:

the age-related meaning of the Greek expression.

Therefore translation can influence theological interpretation.

The present study deliberately chooses **long-age** in order to make the underlying *aiōn* relationship visible.

44. Proposed Translation Table

Greek	Traditional rendering	Translation used in this study
αἰών	age / eternity	age

αἰώνιος	eternal / everlasting	long-age
πῦρ αἰώνιον	eternal fire	long-age fire
κόλασις αἰώνιος	eternal punishment	long-age punishment
ζωή αἰώνιος	eternal life	long-age life
δεσμοὶς αἰωνίοις	eternal chains	long-age chains

This table represents the **translation policy of the present study**, not a claim that all English translations or lexicons should adopt these renderings.

45. Theological Model of Sin

The research began with the proposition that sin causes spiritual death.

The resulting model is:

Sin

↓

Moral corruption

↓

Distorted thinking

↓

Weakening conscience

↓

Habitual sin

↓

Bondage

↓

Spiritual death

This model is consistent with biblical passages describing sin as slavery and spiritual death.

46. Theological Model of Judgment

The judgment model can then be represented:

Physical death

↓

Sheol / Hades

↓

Resurrection

↓

Judgment

↓

Long-age punishment / judgment

↓

Second death

The precise relationship between these stages varies among biblical passages, and the model should therefore be understood as a synthesis rather than as a single verse's chronological sequence.

47. Hades and the Second Death

Revelation 20 provides particularly important evidence.

Death and Hades give up their dead.

Then Death and Hades are thrown into the lake of fire.

The text says:

“This is the second death, the lake of fire.”

Therefore:

Hades

is not identical to:

the second death.

This distinction should be maintained throughout biblical theology.

48. The Meaning of “Death”

The word “death” itself requires contextual interpretation.

It may describe:

- physical death,
- spiritual death,
- metaphorical separation,
- final death.

Consequently, when Revelation calls the lake of fire the “second death,” it should not automatically be interpreted according to every other use of “death.”

The expression is a specific eschatological designation.

49. Final Judgment and the Soul

Matthew 10:28 provides a crucial connection:

“destroy both soul and body in Gehenna.”

This passage prevents a simplistic equation between:

physical death

and

complete annihilation of human existence.

The text explicitly distinguishes soul and body.

At the same time, the verb *apollymi* introduces the language of destruction/perishing.

Thus the passage is relevant to all three major theological questions:

1. What is the soul?
2. What does destruction mean?
3. What happens in Gehenna?

50. Long-Age Fire and the Human Soul

If *aiōnios* is interpreted as long-age, then:

long-age fire

describes the fire of the judgment age.

The question of what happens to the soul during and after that judgment must be addressed separately.

This distinction is crucial.

The word *aiōnios* tells us about the character or duration of the fire according to the chosen interpretation.

It does not, by itself, provide a complete anthropology of the soul.

51. The Relationship Between Punishment and Destruction

A major theological question is whether:

punishment

and

destruction

are mutually exclusive.

They need not be.

A person can undergo punishment through destruction.

Thus Matthew 25:46's *kolasis* and Matthew 10:28's *apollymi* should not automatically be placed into opposing theological categories.

The Bible may describe the same divine judgment using different conceptual vocabulary.

52. Long-Age Punishment as a Process or Condition

Under the present thesis, “long-age punishment” may be understood as:

the divine punitive judgment associated with the coming age.

This does not necessarily define the exact mechanism.

It may involve:

- conscious judgment,
- separation,
- destruction,
- death,
- or a combination of judgment imagery.

The final theological conclusion must therefore be derived from the whole biblical witness.

53. Long-Age Life as a Divine Gift

The corresponding phrase:

long-age life

describes the life associated with the coming age.

This life is not merely biological existence.

It represents:

- fellowship with God,
- resurrection,
- righteousness,
- kingdom participation,
- victory over death.

Thus “long-age life” is fundamentally theological rather than merely chronological.

54. The Resurrection as the Key to Immortality

The New Testament's strongest discussion of immortality occurs in resurrection theology.

Paul emphasizes:

mortality → immortality

and:

corruption → incorruption.

Therefore, the ultimate hope of biblical Christianity is not simply escape from the body.

It is:

resurrection life.

This is an important correction to approaches that make the immortal soul the center of biblical eschatology while neglecting resurrection.

55. The Unborn Soul Hypothesis

The proposition that the soul is “unborn” presents an additional philosophical question.

Biblical texts speak of:

- creation,
- God's breath,
- life,
- soul,
- birth,
- death,
- resurrection.

However, the Hebrew and Greek words examined here do not themselves establish the philosophical claim that the soul existed before the person's birth.

Therefore, if the doctrine of an **unborn soul** is to be defended, it requires a separate philosophical and theological argument.

The present paper does not treat *nephesh* or *psychē* as lexical proof of pre-existence.

56. The Immortal Soul and the Second Death

If the soul is immortal, then the “second death” cannot mean annihilation of the soul in a straightforward sense.

If immortality is conditional and granted through resurrection, the second death may have a different significance.

This demonstrates why anthropology and eschatology must be studied together.

The doctrine of the soul affects the interpretation of:

- death,
 - resurrection,
 - judgment,
 - destruction,
 - and second death.
-

57. Theological Caution Concerning Lucifer

The traditional Lucifer doctrine should not be used as primary evidence for *aiōnios*.

Isaiah 14 directly concerns the king of Babylon.

Ezekiel 28 directly concerns the king of Tyre.

The Satanic interpretation is an important theological tradition, but it is not a lexical definition of *aiōnios*.

Therefore:

Lucifer's fall may serve as a theological analogy concerning exalted status and subsequent judgment, but it cannot independently prove that *aiōnios* means long-age.

This distinction strengthens rather than weakens the argument.

58. A Proposed Interpretation of Matthew 25:46

Within the interpretive framework of this study:

“And these shall go away into long-age punishment, but the righteous into long-age life.”

The verse describes two contrasting destinies associated with the eschatological age.

The adjective is translated consistently.

The distinction is:

punishment

versus

life.

The verse therefore does not need to be interpreted as:

endless punishment versus endless life

solely because the English translation says “eternal.”

Instead, the broader biblical context must determine the ultimate duration.

59. A Proposed Interpretation of Matthew 25:41

Matthew 25:41:

πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον

is rendered:

“the long-age fire.”

The phrase describes the fire associated with eschatological judgment.

The term does not, on this interpretation, function as an explicit mathematical statement that the fire must burn endlessly.

The fire belongs to the divine judgment of the age.

60. A Proposed Interpretation of Matthew 18:8

Matthew 18:8 likewise speaks of:

the long-age fire.

The context emphasizes the seriousness of sin.

Jesus' teaching is not intended to minimize sin.

Rather, it demonstrates that sin has consequences severe enough to require radical moral action.

The long-age interpretation therefore does not weaken the biblical warning.

It changes the proposed understanding of the duration and character of the judgment.

61. The Moral Meaning of Judgment

Regardless of one's interpretation of the duration of final punishment, Scripture presents sin as morally serious.

Sin:

- destroys relationships,
- corrupts character,
- weakens conscience,
- produces bondage,
- separates people from God,
- and leads to judgment.

Therefore, the doctrine of judgment is fundamentally connected to biblical morality.

62. The Purpose of the Warning

Jesus' warnings about Gehenna and fire are intended to produce repentance.

The purpose is not speculation about chronology.

The message is:

Do not allow sin to dominate your life.

This fits the earlier concept of spiritual death.

The person who continually gives himself to sin becomes increasingly separated from God.

63. Spiritual Death and Spiritual Life

The Bible presents spiritual life as the opposite of spiritual death.

Paul says:

“God ... made us alive together with Christ.”

Therefore:

sin → spiritual death

but:

God's mercy → spiritual life.

This transformation is central to Christian theology.

64. Synthesis of the Word Study

The major terms can now be summarized.

***Nephesh* — H5315**

Soul, life, person, self, living being.

***Psychē* — G5590**

Soul, life, self, person.

***Sheol* — H7585**

Realm/condition associated with the dead.

***Hades* — G86**

Realm/condition associated with the dead.

***Gehenna* — G1067**

Judgment-related terminology.

***Thanatos* — G2288**

Death.

***Aiōn* — G165**

Age, epoch, era, broader temporal sense.

***Aiōnios* — G166**

The adjective investigated here as “long-age”; also traditionally rendered eternal/everlasting.

***Kolasis* — G2851**

Punishment/penalty.

***Apollymi* — G622**

Destroy, perish, lose, ruin.

Second death

The lake of fire according to Revelation 20:14.

65. The Proposed Biblical Framework

The research can now be represented:

Stage 1 — Sin

Sin enters human moral life.

↓

Stage 2 — Corruption

The person becomes morally and spiritually corrupted.

↓

Stage 3 — Spiritual Death

The person becomes separated from God.



Stage 4 — Physical Death

The earthly bodily life ends.



Stage 5 — Sheol/Hades

The biblical vocabulary describes the realm/condition of the dead.



Stage 6 — Resurrection

The dead are raised.



Stage 7 — Judgment

God judges humanity.



Stage 8 — Long-Age Judgment

The judgment passages describe fire and punishment with *aiōnios*, interpreted here as **long-age**.



Stage 9 — Second Death

Revelation identifies the lake of fire as the second death.

This is a theological synthesis and must not be confused with a single biblical passage presenting the entire sequence.

66. Major Conclusions

The study reaches the following conclusions.

Conclusion 1

Sin can produce spiritual death.

Conclusion 2

Sin can corrupt the moral and spiritual nature of the person.

Conclusion 3

Nephesh and *psychē* have broad meanings and should not automatically be equated with an inherently immortal soul.

Conclusion 4

Sheol and Hades are associated with the dead and should be distinguished from the lake of fire.

Conclusion 5

Gehenna is a distinct judgment-related term.

Conclusion 6

The lake of fire is explicitly called the second death.

Conclusion 7

Aiōn has a significant age-related semantic dimension.

Conclusion 8

This study adopts **long-age** as the translation of *aiōnios* in its principal judgment passages.

Conclusion 9

“Long-age fire” is therefore the preferred translation of *πῦρ αἰώνιον* within this study.

Conclusion 10

Matthew 25:46 must be translated consistently because the same adjective modifies both punishment and life.

Conclusion 11

The long-age interpretation does not by itself prove that punishment is temporary.

Conclusion 12

The final duration and nature of judgment must be determined through the wider biblical evidence.

67. Final Theological Thesis

The central thesis of this research can be stated as follows:

Sin produces spiritual death by corrupting the moral and spiritual nature of the human person and separating the person from God. The Hebrew *nephesh* and Greek *psychē* describe the person, life, self, or soul and should not be reduced to a single philosophical definition of an inherently immortal soul. *Sheol* and *Hades* concern the realm or condition of the dead, while *Gehenna* belongs particularly to the vocabulary of divine judgment. Revelation distinguishes Hades from the lake of fire and explicitly identifies the lake of fire as the second death. The Greek *aiōn* denotes an age or age-related period in many contexts, and this study interprets its adjective *aiōnios* as “long-age” in the principal eschatological judgment passages. Accordingly, *πῦρ αἰώνιον* is rendered “long-age fire,” *κόλασις αἰώνιος* as “long-age punishment,” and *ζωὴ αἰώνιος* as “long-age life.” This interpretation does not deny the traditional eternal interpretation but argues that it should not be assumed solely from English translation. The ultimate nature and duration of final judgment must be determined from the total biblical witness.

68. Final Conclusion

The biblical concepts of sin, death, soul, judgment, and the afterlife cannot be adequately understood by relying on English terminology alone.

The Hebrew **nephesh** and Greek **psychē** reveal that the biblical concept of the soul is more complex than the simple philosophical expression “immortal soul.”

Sheol and **Hades** belong to the biblical vocabulary concerning the dead.

Gehenna represents a distinct vocabulary of judgment.

Thanatos describes death and can function in both physical and spiritual contexts.

The **second death** is explicitly associated with the lake of fire in Revelation.

The most significant linguistic debate concerns **aiōn** and **aiōnios**.

This study deliberately uses “**long-age**” for *aiōnios* in its principal eschatological passages.

Thus:

πῦρ αἰώνιον — long-age fire

κόλασιν αἰώνιον — long-age punishment

ζωὴν αἰώνιον — long-age life

This translation draws attention to the relationship between *aiōnios* and *aiōn* and to the New Testament distinction between the present age and the age to come.

However, the study recognizes that *aiōnios* also has an established traditional interpretation as “eternal” or “everlasting.” The long-age thesis must therefore be defended through contextual exegesis rather than by claiming that the alternative does not exist.

The strongest conclusion is consequently methodological:

The meaning of a biblical word must be determined by its usage, context, grammar, literary setting, and relationship to the wider biblical witness.

The study therefore rejects two extremes.

The first extreme is:

“Aiōnios can only mean eternal, so no other interpretation is possible.”

The second is:

“Aiōnios can only mean a temporary period, so eternal is impossible.”

Instead, this research proposes:

“Long-age” is the interpretive translation adopted for the eschatological passages studied here, and its validity must be tested through the entire biblical context.

The central moral message remains unchanged:

Sin produces spiritual death.

Sin corrupts the person.

Sin weakens moral judgment.

Sin can become bondage.

Sin separates the person from God.

But Scripture also presents the possibility of spiritual life.

The person who is spiritually dead can be made spiritually alive.

The ultimate biblical hope is therefore not merely escape from punishment but **reconciliation with God, resurrection, righteousness, and life in the coming age.**

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Appendix A — Strong's Number Index

Biblical term	Original language	Transliteration	Strong's
Soul/person	נֶפֶשׁ	<i>nephesh</i>	H5315
Sheol	שְׁאוֹל	<i>Sheol</i>	H7585
Soul/life	ψυχή	<i>psychē</i>	G5590
Hades	Ἅδης	<i>Hades</i>	G86
Gehenna	γέεννα	<i>Gehenna</i>	G1067
Death	θάνατος	<i>thanatos</i>	G2288
Age	αἰών	<i>aiōn</i>	G165
Long-age	αἰώνιος	<i>aiōnios</i>	G166
Punishment	κόλασις	<i>kolasis</i>	G2851
Destroy/perish	ἀπόλλυμι	<i>apollymi</i>	G622
Fire	πῦρ	<i>pyr</i>	G4442
Second	δεύτερος	<i>deuteros</i>	G1208
Life	ζωή	<i>zōē</i>	G2222
Unquenchable	ἄσβεστος	<i>asbestos</i>	G762

Appendix B — Principal Biblical Passages

Sin and Spiritual Death

- Genesis 2:17
- Romans 5:12
- Romans 6:23
- Ephesians 2:1–5
- Colossians 2:13

Soul and Person

- Genesis 2:7
- Ezekiel 18:4
- Ezekiel 18:20
- Matthew 10:28
- Mark 8:35
- Revelation 6:9

Sheol and Hades

- Genesis 37:35
- Psalm 6:5
- Psalm 16:10
- Psalm 49:15
- Acts 2:27
- Revelation 20:13–14

Gehenna

- Matthew 5:22
- Matthew 5:29–30
- Matthew 10:28
- Matthew 18:9
- Mark 9:43–48
- Luke 12:5
- James 3:6

Long-Age / *Aiōnios*

- Matthew 18:8
- Matthew 19:16
- Matthew 19:29
- Matthew 25:41
- Matthew 25:46
- Mark 10:30
- John 3:16
- Romans 16:26
- Jude 6–7

Second Death

- Revelation 2:11
 - Revelation 20:6
 - Revelation 20:14
 - Revelation 21:8
-

Appendix C — Core Translation Thesis

For consistency, this study uses the following translation framework:

αἰών (*aiōn*) → age

αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*) → long-age

πῦρ αἰώνιον → long-age fire

κόλασις αἰώνιος → long-age punishment

ζωὴ αἰώνιος → long-age life

This is the **interpretive translation policy of this research paper**. It is not presented as though there were no competing lexical interpretation.

The purpose is to investigate whether the biblical texts themselves require the concept of **endless duration**, or whether the expressions can be understood in relation to **the coming age and its divine judgment**.

Final Research Statement

Sin causes spiritual death. Sin corrupts the person, damages moral thinking, weakens conscience, and can bring a person into bondage. Scripture distinguishes spiritual death from physical death and distinguishes Sheol/Hades from the final second death. The human soul is described through the broad Hebrew and Greek concepts of *nephesh* and *psychē*. Revelation identifies the lake of fire as the second death. The Greek *aiōn* is fundamentally associated with age or age-period terminology, and this study interprets its adjective *aiōnios* as “long-age” in the principal judgment passages. Therefore, “long-age fire,” “long-age punishment,” and “long-age life” are used as the paper's proposed translations. The final nature and duration of divine judgment must nevertheless be established through comprehensive contextual exegesis rather than through translation tradition alone.

Part II — Long-Age Life, the Fall, and the Nature of *Aiōnios*

23. The Concept of Long-Age Life

The preceding sections established that the Greek adjective αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*, Strong's G166) is closely related to αἰών (*aiōn*, G165), a noun that can denote an age, epoch, or period.

This study adopts “**long-age**” as its translation of *aiōnios* in the principal judgment passages under investigation.

Accordingly:

αἰών — *aiōn*
= age

αἰώνιος — *aiōnios*
= long-age

αἰώνιον — *aiōnion*
= long-age, in the relevant grammatical forms

This produces the following translations:

ζωὴ αἰώνιος
→ **long-age life**

κόλασις αἰώνιος
→ **long-age punishment**

πῦρ αἰώνιον
→ **long-age fire**

The purpose of this translation is not to deny that many English translations render *aiōnios* as “eternal.” Rather, it is to investigate whether the Greek term necessarily requires the concept of an existence that can never terminate.

The question is therefore:

Does “long-age” describe an extended age-related condition, or must it necessarily describe endless duration?

This question becomes especially significant when biblical passages describe beings who possessed an exalted or heavenly status but subsequently fell from that status.

24. Long-Age Life and the Possibility of Change

The concept of **long-age life** raises an important theological distinction.

Something may belong to an age or endure throughout a long age without the word itself logically meaning that the condition can never change.

In other words:

Long-age does not necessarily mean unchangeable.

This distinction is important when considering biblical narratives involving beings who possessed extraordinary status but subsequently experienced judgment or fall.

The strongest biblical examples must, however, be handled carefully.

25. Lucifer and the Tradition of the Fallen Heavenly Being

The name “**Lucifer**” is traditionally associated with the fallen heavenly being later identified with Satan.

The traditional connection is particularly associated with **Isaiah 14:12–15**, where the Hebrew text refers to **הִילֵל** (*hélēl*), commonly rendered “morning star,” “shining one,” or represented in Latin tradition by *Lucifer*.

Isaiah 14, however, directly occurs within an oracle against the **king of Babylon**.

Therefore, an academically responsible study must distinguish:

Textual level

Isaiah 14 addresses the king of Babylon.

Traditional theological level

Later Jewish and Christian interpretation connected the passage with the fall of Satan or a primordial heavenly rebel.

The theological association is therefore important, but it should not be presented as though the Hebrew word *hēlēl* literally means “Satan.”

26. Isaiah 14 and the Fall from Exalted Position

Isaiah 14:12–15 describes an exalted figure who says, in effect:

“I will ascend to heaven;
I will exalt my throne above the stars of God.”

The figure then experiences humiliation and descent.

The theological pattern is significant:

Exalted position

↓

Pride

↓

Attempted elevation

↓

Judgment

↓

Fall

This pattern is relevant to the broader theological question of whether an exalted condition necessarily means an irreversible condition.

It demonstrates conceptually that **high status does not necessarily imply permanent status**.

However, this passage alone does not establish the meaning of *aiōnios*.

27. Ezekiel 28 and the Edenic Figure

Ezekiel 28 provides another important text.

The oracle is explicitly directed against the **king of Tyre**.

Yet the language is extraordinary:

“You were in Eden, the garden of God.”

The passage describes precious stones, a holy mountain, a cherub, wisdom, beauty, and subsequent expulsion.

Because of this language, Christian tradition has often interpreted Ezekiel 28 as having a secondary reference to Satan.

Modern scholarship, however, emphasizes the complexity of the passage. Some scholars understand the Edenic imagery as a symbolic portrayal of the Tyrian king, while others have explored possible supernatural or mythological dimensions.

One recent scholarly study argues that Ezekiel's imagery portrays the king of Tyre through an Edenic/Adamic framework and emphasizes that the text concerns the king's exalted status and subsequent downfall.

Thus, the safest formulation is:

Ezekiel 28 explicitly concerns the king of Tyre, while its Edenic and cherubic imagery has contributed to later theological interpretations concerning a primordial heavenly fall.

28. The Important Point for the Present Study

Why are Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 relevant to a study of *aiōnios*?

Not because they prove the lexical meaning of *aiōnios*.

Rather, they illustrate a theological principle:

An exalted or heavenly condition can be followed by a fall and judgment.

If a person or being possesses an extended, age-related existence, that existence does not necessarily mean that every circumstance within that existence is irreversible.

This is the principle that the present study calls:

The Long-Age Principle

A condition may be associated with an age without the adjective itself necessarily defining that condition as intrinsically endless or incapable of transition.

This principle does not prove the interpretation of Matthew 25:46. It establishes a conceptual framework for examining it.

29. Jude 6 and the Heavenly Beings Who Sinned

Jude 6 provides a particularly important passage:

“And the angels who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper dwelling, he has kept in eternal [*aiōniois*] chains under darkness for the judgment of the great day.”

The Greek contains an inflected form of **αιώνιος**.

Under the translation adopted in this paper:

“long-age chains.”

This passage is important because the angels are already under a condition of confinement **for judgment**.

The text therefore connects:

sin

→ **loss of proper position**

→ **confinement**

→ **future judgment**

This fits the broader biblical theme that a previously elevated status does not necessarily prevent subsequent judgment.

30. 2 Peter 2:4 and the Sinning Angels

Second Peter 2:4 similarly speaks of angels who sinned:

“God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into Tartarus and committed them to chains of gloomy darkness to be kept until judgment.”

The passage introduces another important distinction:

present confinement

and

future judgment

The angels are being kept **until judgment**.

This means that biblical judgment terminology can describe an intermediate condition before the final judgment.

That observation is important when constructing a theology of:

- spiritual death,
 - physical death,
 - Hades,
 - judgment,
 - and final punishment.
-

31. Long-Age Life in Matthew 25:46

Matthew 25:46 is central to this research.

The Greek text reads:

καὶ ἀπελεύσονται οὗτοι εἰς κόλασιν αἰώνιον, οἱ δὲ δίκαιοι εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον.

A literal structural rendering is:

“And these will go away into punishment αἰώνιον, but the righteous into life αἰώνιον.”

Under the translation adopted by this paper:

“And these shall go away into long-age punishment, but the righteous into long-age life.”

The same adjective occurs twice.

First occurrence

κόλασιν αἰώνιον

→ **long-age punishment**

Second occurrence

ζωὴν αἰώνιον

→ **long-age life**

This parallel cannot be ignored.

32. Long-Age Life Does Not Necessarily Mean Endless Life by Lexical Definition

The traditional translation:

“eternal life”

has become deeply embedded in Christian theology.

However, the Greek expression itself consists of:

ζωή — life

and

αἰώνιος — long-age

Therefore, if the research adopts *aiōnios* as “long-age,” the expression becomes:

long-age life

The important theological question is then:

Does “long-age life” mean life that belongs to or characterizes the coming age, or does it necessarily specify an endless duration?

The word itself does not answer every aspect of this question.

Context must be considered.

33. The Parallelism of Matthew 25:46

One of the strongest objections to translating *aiōnios* as “long-age” is the parallelism of Matthew 25:46.

The same adjective modifies both:

punishment

and

life.

This means an interpreter cannot simply say:

“*Aiōnios* means temporary when it describes punishment but eternal when it describes life.”

Such a reading would require an explanation.

The long-age interpretation therefore proposes something different:

Both expressions refer to realities associated with the age to come.

Thus:

long-age punishment

and

long-age life

are parallel descriptions of the two destinies associated with the coming age.

The question of whether the life itself continues beyond the age must then be addressed from other biblical passages concerning resurrection and immortality.

34. The Age to Come

Jesus and the New Testament writers repeatedly distinguish between:

this age

and

the age to come.

This is expressed through *aiōn* terminology.

For example, Mark 10:30 speaks of:

“the age to come.”

The Greek expression is:

ἐν τῷ αἰῶνι τῷ ἐρχομένῳ

literally:

“in the age that is coming.”

This demonstrates that *aiōn* can refer to an identifiable eschatological age.

Consequently, the adjective *aiōnios* deserves to be examined in relation to this “age to come.”

35. Long-Age Fire

The expression commonly translated:

“eternal fire”

contains the Greek:

πῦρ αἰώνιον

where:

- **πῦρ (pyr, G4442)** = fire
- **αἰώνιον (aiōnion, G166)** = long-age, according to the translation adopted in this study

Therefore:

πῦρ αἰώνιον → long-age fire

This terminology occurs in Matthew 18:8 and Matthew 25:41.

The paper's thesis is that the expression should not automatically be understood as describing a fire that burns endlessly without interruption.

Instead, it can be investigated as:

fire belonging to or operating throughout the long age associated with divine judgment.

36. Matthew 18:8

Matthew 18:8 speaks of being:

“thrown into the eternal fire.”

The Greek expression is:

εἰς τὸ πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον

Under this paper's translation:

“into the long-age fire.”

The expression contains the article and adjective agreeing with the noun *pyr*.

The grammatical observation is straightforward:

pyr = fire

aiōnion = adjective modifying fire

Therefore, the debate is not about whether the word “fire” is present. It is about the temporal and qualitative force of *aiōnion*.

37. Matthew 25:41

Matthew 25:41 contains another important occurrence:

τὸ πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον

Traditionally:

“the eternal fire”

This paper renders it:

“the long-age fire.”

The significance is that the phrase appears within an eschatological judgment scene.

The “fire” is associated with judgment.

The question is therefore:

Does *aiōnios* describe the fire's endless duration, or does it identify the fire with the coming age of judgment?

The present study argues for the second possibility.

38. The Meaning of “Long-Age”

The phrase “**long-age**” should not be misunderstood as merely meaning “a short period.”

An age may be extraordinarily long.

The term is therefore intended to communicate:

an extended, age-related period belonging to the divine order under discussion.

The concept is broader than ordinary human chronological measurement.

Thus:

long-age fire

does not mean:

“a fire that lasts for a few minutes.”

It means:

“fire associated with or extending through the relevant divine age.”

39. Long-Age Punishment

Matthew 25:46 uses:

κόλασιν αἰώνιον

The noun *kolasis* means punishment or penalty in its ordinary lexical range.

Therefore, this paper does not require *kolasis* to mean “correction” merely because some historical interpretations have emphasized its etymological background.

The proposed translation is:

long-age punishment

The key question is the duration and purpose of that punishment.

The word *aiōnios* is being interpreted as age-related rather than automatically as infinite duration.

40. The Difference Between “Long-Age” and “Temporary”

A critical distinction must be maintained.

The argument:

aiōnios = long-age

does **not** automatically mean:

aiōnios = temporary in the sense of brief.

An age may be:

- long,
- extended,
- climactic,
- eschatological,
- and of enormous theological significance.

Therefore, the long-age interpretation does not by itself determine what happens **after** the age.

This is especially important for the phrase:

long-age life

The righteous may receive life associated with the coming age, and the question of whether that life continues beyond the age must be established from the wider biblical teaching.

41. The Long-Age Interpretation of Matthew 25:46

Under the interpretive framework of this paper:

“And these shall go away into long-age punishment, but the righteous into long-age life.”

The two destinies are parallel.

The wicked

long-age punishment

The righteous

long-age life

The verse therefore contrasts two destinies within the eschatological age.

The verse by itself does not provide a complete metaphysical description of the ultimate state of the soul.

That question requires additional passages.

42. The Soul and the Final Judgment

The distinction between **soul**, **body**, and **judgment** becomes particularly important in Matthew 10:28.

Jesus says:

“Fear him who is able to destroy both soul and body in Gehenna.”

The Greek contains:

ψυχή — psychē

and

σῶμα — sōma

and

ἀπόλλυμι — apollymi

and

γέεννα — Gehenna

The passage therefore brings together four major theological concepts:

1. soul,
2. body,
3. destruction,
4. judgment.

It should be studied independently from the meaning of *aiōnios*.

43. Spiritual Death and Final Judgment

The present study proposes the following distinction:

Spiritual death

A condition produced by sin.

Physical death

The end of earthly bodily life.

Hades/Sheol

The biblical realm/condition associated with the dead.

Resurrection

The restoration of bodily life for judgment and/or life.

Final judgment

The divine judgment of persons.

Second death

The final judgment identified with the lake of fire in Revelation.

This framework avoids treating every biblical reference to “death” or “hell” as identical.

44. The Second Death Is Not Simply Hades

Revelation 20:13–14 is decisive for terminology:

“Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them.”

Then:

“Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire.”

And:

“This is the second death, the lake of fire.”

The sequence is:

Death + Hades

↓

give up the dead

↓

judgment

↓

Death + Hades thrown into lake of fire

↓

lake of fire = second death

This demonstrates that **Hades and the second death are distinguishable concepts.**

45. The Lake of Fire and Long-Age Fire

The New Testament contains two related but distinct expressions:

πῦρ αἰώνιον

→ long-age fire

and

λίμνη τοῦ πυρός

→ lake of fire

The first is particularly prominent in Jesus' judgment warnings.

The second is prominent in Revelation.

They should not be automatically equated without examining their respective contexts.

Nevertheless, both belong to the broader biblical theology of final judgment.

46. Long-Age Fire and the Traditional Translation

Traditional translations commonly render:

πῦρ αἰώνιον

as:

“eternal fire”

The present study instead uses:

“long-age fire.”

The reason is methodological:

1. *aiōn* can denote an age.
2. *aiōnios* is derived from *aiōn*.
3. The New Testament speaks explicitly of “this age” and “the age to come.”
4. Judgment is repeatedly associated with the coming age.
5. Therefore, *aiōnios* in judgment contexts deserves contextual examination rather than automatic identification with endless duration.

This does not prove the long-age interpretation by itself, but it provides the basis for further exegesis.

47. The Strongest Counterargument

The strongest counterargument is that *aiōnios* can also be used in contexts where everlasting or unending existence appears to be intended.

For example, *aiōnios* is used of God and of life.

Furthermore, Matthew 25:46 uses the same adjective for punishment and life.

Therefore, a scholarly paper must acknowledge:

The traditional “eternal” interpretation has genuine linguistic and contextual support.

The long-age interpretation cannot be defended by pretending otherwise.

Its strongest form is instead:

The semantic range of *aiōnios* is broad enough that the judgment passages must be interpreted contextually, and “long-age” is a legitimate interpretive possibility that should not be excluded merely because English translations traditionally use “eternal.”

48. The Lucifer Analogy Revisited

The Lucifer analogy can now be stated more carefully.

It is not:

“The Bible says Lucifer had *aiōnios* life.”

It does not say that.

Rather:

Biblical traditions concerning the fall of an exalted heavenly being demonstrate the conceptual possibility that an exalted or heavenly condition can be followed by judgment and loss of status.

Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 are the primary texts behind this traditional association, although their immediate historical referents and theological interpretations are debated.

Ezekiel 28 scholarship in particular demonstrates substantial disagreement concerning whether the cherub imagery identifies the king with a supernatural being or portrays the human king through Edenic and cherubic symbolism.

Thus the Lucifer analogy should remain a **theological analogy**, not a lexical proof.

49. The Broader Biblical Principle

The broader principle can be expressed as:

Exalted status does not automatically equal irrevocable status.

Biblical narratives contain multiple examples of beings or persons who possessed privilege and subsequently experienced judgment.

This includes:

- Adam,
- Israel,
- kings,
- angels who sinned,
- and the traditional Lucifer/Satan interpretation.

Therefore, the concept of an age-related state followed by judgment is not foreign to biblical theology.

50. Long-Age Life and Eternal Life

A further distinction is necessary.

The paper uses:

long-age life

rather than:

eternal life

when translating *zōē aiōnios*.

This does not necessarily deny that the righteous ultimately live forever.

Instead, it argues that the adjective itself should first be understood according to its age-related semantic relationship.

The wider New Testament may then establish whether the life of the coming age continues without end.

In other words:

The adjective identifies the life with the age; the wider theology determines its ultimate duration.

This distinction is essential to the research.

51. Resurrection and Immortality

Paul's teaching in 1 Corinthians 15 is particularly important.

Paul does not describe resurrection merely as the continuation of an immortal soul.

He places extraordinary emphasis on the resurrection of the body.

He writes:

“This mortal must put on immortality.”

The language of **putting on immortality** suggests that immortality is a divine transformation.

Therefore, Christian anthropology should not be reduced to:

“the soul is naturally immortal.”

The biblical doctrine of resurrection must remain central.

52. The Immortal Soul Hypothesis

The claim that the soul is “unborn and immortal” therefore needs qualification.

What the lexical evidence establishes

Nephesh and *psychē* can refer to the soul/person/life/self.

What Matthew 10:28 establishes

Jesus distinguishes soul from body in a particular context.

What 1 Corinthians 15 establishes

Immortality is associated with resurrection transformation.

What 1 Timothy 6:16 establishes

God is uniquely characterized as possessing immortality.

Therefore, the doctrine of an immortal soul cannot be established simply by quoting the dictionary meaning of *nephesh* or *psychē*.

53. Proposed Biblical Model

The research now produces the following conceptual model:

SIN



MORAL CORRUPTION



SPIRITUAL DEATH



PHYSICAL DEATH



SHEOL / HADES



RESURRECTION



JUDGMENT



LONG-AGE PUNISHMENT / JUDGMENT



SECOND DEATH / LAKE OF FIRE

This model represents the thesis of the study and should be tested against the individual biblical passages.

54. The Long-Age Interpretation: Strengths

The interpretation has several potential strengths.

1. It recognizes the relationship between *aiōn* and *aiōnios*.

The adjective is connected linguistically with the noun “age.”

2. It takes “this age” and “the age to come” seriously.

The New Testament clearly uses age terminology for eschatological periods.

3. It avoids automatically importing the later philosophical concept of endless duration.

The English word “eternal” can carry philosophical assumptions that must be tested against the Greek.

4. It permits contextual interpretation.

The meaning is determined by the biblical context rather than by one English translation.

5. It creates a consistent translation of Matthew 25:46.

The same adjective is translated consistently:

long-age punishment

and

long-age life.

55. The Long-Age Interpretation: Challenges

The interpretation also faces substantial challenges.

1. *Aiōnios* can have an eternal sense.

Some Greek lexicons understand the word as “eternal” or “everlasting.”

2. Matthew 25:46 is parallel.

The same adjective modifies punishment and life.

3. Christian tradition overwhelmingly translated the term as eternal.

The traditional interpretation therefore has a long history.

4. Some contexts appear to require permanence.

The adjective is used of God and other realities that may be understood as everlasting.

5. “Long-age” does not automatically prove temporary punishment.

The conclusion requires additional arguments concerning what happens after the age.

A credible research paper must acknowledge each of these difficulties.

56. A More Precise Thesis

The thesis of this paper should therefore not be:

“Greek *aiōnios* can only mean long-age.”

That claim is too absolute.

The more defensible thesis is:

“The Greek adjective *aiōnios* is related to *aiōn*, ‘age,’ and possesses an age-related semantic dimension. In the eschatological judgment passages examined in this study, it can reasonably be interpreted as ‘long-age.’ Accordingly, expressions traditionally

rendered ‘eternal fire’ and ‘eternal punishment’ may be translated ‘long-age fire’ and ‘long-age punishment.’ This interpretation should be evaluated against the wider New Testament evidence concerning the age to come, resurrection, judgment, destruction, and the second death.”

This is a stronger scholarly formulation because it makes a **positive argument without claiming that competing lexical evidence does not exist.**

57. Preliminary Conclusion of Part II

The concept of **long-age life** provides an important framework for reconsidering the traditional translation of *aiōnios*.

Matthew 25:46 contains the same adjective in:

long-age punishment

and

long-age life.

Matthew 18:8 and Matthew 25:41 contain:

long-age fire.

The biblical language therefore invites a serious investigation of whether *aiōnios* necessarily communicates endless duration or whether, in eschatological contexts, it can describe realities belonging to the coming age.

The traditional identification of Lucifer with a fallen heavenly being can contribute a **theological analogy** concerning exalted status followed by fall, but Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 should not be used as direct lexical evidence for *aiōnios*. Modern scholarship emphasizes that Ezekiel 28 primarily concerns the king of Tyre and that its cherubic/Edenic imagery is complex and disputed.

Therefore, the next stage of the research must move beyond *aiōnios* itself.

The crucial words are:

κόλασις (*kolasis*) — punishment

ἀπόλλυμι (*apollymi*) — destroy/perish

πῦρ (*pyr*) — fire

ἄσβεστος (*asbestos*) — unquenchable

αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*) — long-age

and

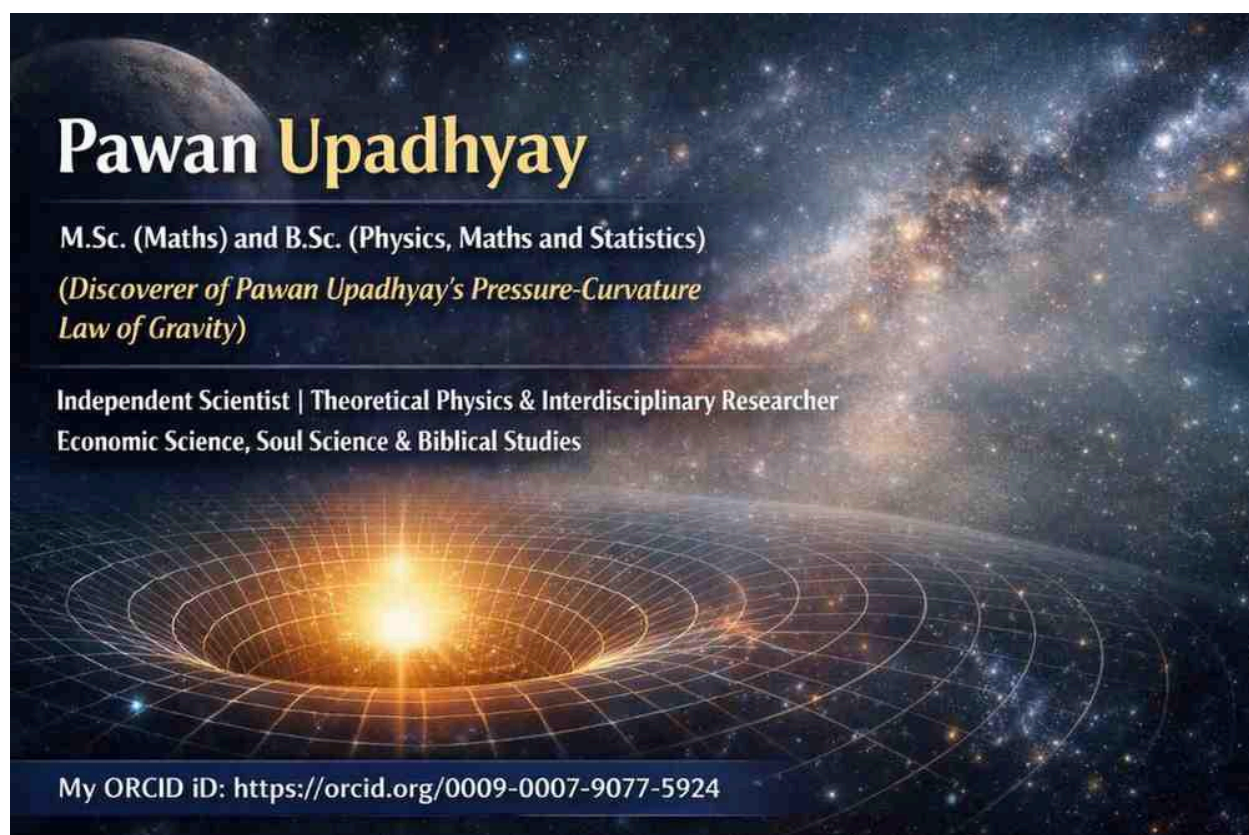
δεύτερος θάνατος (*deuteros thanatos*) — second death.

Together, these terms must be examined to determine whether the biblical picture is best understood as **endless conscious punishment, age-long punishment followed by another state, destruction, or another theological model.**

That investigation forms the next major section of the research.

Blog Version

Sin, Spiritual Death, and the Punishment of the Soul



Introduction

Sin is not merely the breaking of a religious rule. Sin has a destructive effect upon the moral and spiritual nature of a person. It corrupts the heart, weakens the conscience, damages virtuous thinking, and gradually separates a person from God.

The Bible therefore speaks of **spiritual death** as a consequence of sin. A person may be physically alive while being spiritually dead because of separation from God.

“The wages of sin is death.” — Romans 6:23

This death is not necessarily the immediate destruction of the person or the soul. Rather, spiritual death describes a condition in which the person is separated from the life and righteousness of God.

1. Sin Is the Cause of Spiritual Death

The entrance of sin into human life produces spiritual death.

Paul writes:

“You were dead in trespasses and sins.” — Ephesians 2:1

Notice that Paul speaks of people who were **physically alive** but nevertheless “dead” in trespasses and sins. Therefore, spiritual death cannot simply mean physical death.

Spiritual death is a condition produced by sin—a separation from God and from the spiritual life that comes from Him.

Sin damages the relationship between the Creator and the human person.

2. Sin Corrupts the Person

Sin does not remain outside the person. Repeated sinful actions affect the character of the person who commits them.

A person who continually chooses hatred can become hateful. A person who continually chooses deception can become dishonest. A person who continually gives himself to immoral desires can become increasingly controlled by those desires.

Thus, sin can become a form of **moral corruption**.

Jesus taught that evil actions come from within the human heart:

“For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts...” — Mark 7:21

This shows that the problem of sin is deeper than individual actions. Sin can affect the inner character.

3. Sin Destroys Virtuous Thinking

Sin also affects the mind.

Virtue requires the ability to recognize what is good and to choose it. But repeated sin can distort a person's moral judgment. What was once recognized as wrong may gradually appear acceptable.

The conscience can become weakened, and sinful desires can become stronger than the desire for righteousness.

The Bible warns about people who:

“call evil good and good evil.” — Isaiah 5:20

This is one of the terrible effects of moral corruption: the person can gradually lose the proper distinction between good and evil.

4. Sin Can Become an Addiction

At first, a person may choose sin voluntarily. But repeated sinful choices can develop into powerful habits.

The person may eventually feel controlled by the very thing that he originally chose.

Jesus said:

“Everyone who commits sin is a slave to sin.” — John 8:34

This is an important description of the progression of sin.

Choice → Habit → Bondage → Slavery

The person who repeatedly gives himself to sin can become its servant.

This does not mean that repentance and transformation are impossible. Christianity teaches that God can liberate a person from the power of sin.

5. Spiritual Death Is More Than Physical Death

Physical death is the separation of the person from bodily life.

Spiritual death is separation from God because of sin.

These should therefore be distinguished.

A person can be:

Physically alive + spiritually dead.

And after physical death, Scripture also speaks about judgment and punishment.

The final destiny of the wicked is described in Revelation in terms of the “**second death**”:

“This is the second death, the lake of fire.” — Revelation 20:14

Therefore, Scripture uses the language of death in more than one sense.

6. The Soul Is Not Simply Destroyed by Sin

Within the theological understanding presented here, the soul is **unborn and immortal**. The soul does not begin to exist merely when the physical body is born, nor does physical death necessarily mean the annihilation of the soul.

Therefore, spiritual death should not automatically be understood as the extinction of the soul.

Instead, spiritual death can be understood as a **terrible condition of separation from God and corruption through sin**.

The body may die, but the soul continues to exist and remains accountable before God.

Jesus warned:

“Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul.” — Matthew 10:28

This statement distinguishes the **body** from the **soul** and indicates that bodily death does not necessarily mean the destruction of the soul.

7. Judgment After Sin

Christian Scripture teaches that human beings are accountable for their deeds.

Paul writes:

“We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ.” — 2 Corinthians 5:10

And Revelation describes the dead being judged according to their works:

“The dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to what they had done.” — Revelation 20:12

Thus, sin has consequences.

The sinner does not simply escape the moral consequences of his actions because physical life has ended.

8. Hell and the Punishment of Sin

The New Testament contains serious warnings about judgment, hell, and punishment.

Jesus repeatedly warned about **Gehenna**, the place associated with final punishment.

Matthew records:

“It is better for you to enter life with one eye than with two eyes to be thrown into the hell of fire.” — Matthew 18:9

Revelation describes the lake of fire as the final judgment of evil.

The concept of hell therefore expresses the seriousness of sin and the reality of divine judgment.

However, Christians have differed historically concerning the precise nature and duration of hell. Some understand the punishment as everlasting conscious punishment; others understand the final punishment as destruction or annihilation; others have held different views concerning the ultimate restoration of creation.

Therefore, if we argue specifically that the immortal soul suffers in hell **for a long period rather than eternally**, that point should be presented as a particular theological interpretation rather than as an uncontested biblical statement.

9. The Terrible Condition of Spiritual Death

If sin progressively corrupts the person, then spiritual death can be understood as the culmination of this corruption.

The progression can be expressed as:

Sin

↓

Corruption of character

↓

Weakening of conscience

↓

Destruction of virtuous thinking

↓

Habitual sin

↓

Bondage to sin

↓

Spiritual death

↓

Judgment

↓

Punishment

This illustrates why sin should never be regarded as something insignificant.

Every sinful choice has the potential to shape the character of the person.

10. But Spiritual Death Is Not Beyond Redemption

The message of Christianity is not merely that sin produces death. It also teaches that God offers life.

Paul writes:

“But God, being rich in mercy... made us alive together with Christ.” — Ephesians 2:4–5

The person who is spiritually dead can therefore be made spiritually alive.

Repentance turns the person away from sin. Faith turns the person toward God. Transformation restores the moral and spiritual life that sin had damaged.

Jesus said:

“I am the resurrection and the life.” — John 11:25

Therefore, the answer to spiritual death is not merely fear of punishment. It is **turning away from sin and receiving spiritual life from God**.

Conclusion

Sin is spiritually destructive because it does not merely produce individual wrong actions. It can corrupt the person, weaken the conscience, distort moral thinking, destroy virtue, and eventually bring the person into bondage to sinful desires.

This condition can rightly be described as **spiritual death**.

Yet spiritual death does not have to be the final condition of the human person. The biblical message is that God offers forgiveness, repentance, restoration, and life.

The great contrast is therefore:

Sin → Spiritual Death

but

God's grace → Repentance → Spiritual Renewal → Life

The seriousness of sin teaches humanity to fear its consequences, while the mercy of God gives hope that the spiritually dead can be brought back to spiritual life.

Soul, Death, Sheol, Hades, and Gehenna: A Hebrew–Greek Word Study

Introduction

Words such as **soul, death, hell, Sheol, Hades, and Gehenna** are central to biblical discussions about human existence, sin, judgment, and the afterlife. However, English translations can sometimes make different Hebrew and Greek concepts appear to be the same.

For this reason, a study of the original biblical terminology is essential.

The Hebrew Old Testament and Greek New Testament use several different words:

- **Nephesh** — נֶפֶשׁ
- **Psychē** — ψυχή
- **Sheol** — שְׁאוֹל
- **Hades** — Ἅδης
- **Gehenna** — γέεννα
- **Thanatos** — θάνατος
- **Second Death** — δεύτερος θάνατος

These words should not automatically be treated as synonyms.

1. Nephesh — נֶפֶשׁ

The Hebrew word **nephesh** is commonly translated as “**soul**.”

However, its meaning is broader than the English word “soul.”

Depending on context, *nephesh* can refer to:

- a living being
- a person
- life
- self
- desire
- appetite
- the inner life

One of the foundational occurrences is found in Genesis:

“And man became a living soul [*nephesh*].”
— Genesis 2:7

The Hebrew text therefore describes the human being as a **living nephesh**.

This is important because the biblical expression is not necessarily saying that a complete human being consists of a physical body plus an independently existing “soul” that was inserted into the body.

Rather, *nephesh* can describe the **living person himself**.

Can a *nephesh* die?

Yes. The Hebrew Scriptures can speak of the *nephesh* in connection with death.

Ezekiel says:

“The soul [*nephesh*] that sinneth, it shall die.”

— Ezekiel 18:20

Consequently, we should not assume that the Hebrew word *nephesh* by itself means **an inherently immortal soul**.

Its meaning must be determined from its context.

2. Psychē — ψυχή

The principal Greek word corresponding to many uses of “soul” is **psychē**.

It can mean:

- soul
- life
- person
- self
- inner life

For example:

“Whoever would save his life [*psychē*] will lose it.”

— Mark 8:35

Here *psychē* is naturally understood as **life**.

But another passage is particularly significant:

“Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul [*psychē*].”

— Matthew 10:28

Jesus distinguishes:

body → *sōma*

soul → *psychē*

This demonstrates that *psychē* can refer to an aspect of human existence that is not simply identical with the physical body.

However, the word itself does not automatically establish the philosophical doctrine that the soul is inherently immortal.

3. Sheol — שְׁאוֹל

Sheol is one of the most important Old Testament words concerning death.

It is often translated as:

- grave
- Sheol
- realm of the dead
- underworld

The Hebrew Bible associates Sheol with the condition or realm of the dead.

For example:

“In death there is no remembrance of thee: in Sheol who will give thee praise?”
— Psalm 6:5

Jacob also says:

“I will go down to Sheol to my son.”
— Genesis 37:35

These passages demonstrate that **Sheol is associated with death and the dead**.

However, Sheol should not simply be equated with the later Christian concept of **hell as the final place of fiery punishment**.

The biblical vocabulary is more nuanced.

4. Hades — ᾍδης

The Greek New Testament uses **Hades** as a term associated with the realm of the dead.

A particularly important example occurs in Acts 2:27, where Peter quotes Psalm 16:

“You will not abandon my soul to Hades.”

The Greek **Hades** corresponds closely to the Hebrew concept of **Sheol** in this quotation.

Thus we can observe an important linguistic relationship:

Hebrew — Sheol

↓

Greek — Hades

Yet Hades is not necessarily equivalent to the final lake of fire.

Revelation 20:13–14 says:

“Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them.”

Then:

“Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire.”

This distinction is significant.

If **Hades is thrown into the lake of fire**, Hades and the lake of fire cannot simply be identical.

5. Gehenna — γέεννα

The Greek word **Gehenna** is frequently translated as “hell.”

The term is associated historically with the **Valley of Hinnom**, near Jerusalem.

Jesus uses *Gehenna* in several warnings concerning divine judgment.

For example:

“Fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell [*Gehenna*].”
— Matthew 10:28

This verse is especially important because it brings together:

soul → body → destruction → Gehenna

The Greek verb translated “destroy” is **apollymi**.

Therefore, a complete interpretation of Matthew 10:28 requires studying not only *Gehenna*, but also *apollymi*.

This demonstrates why word studies should examine the entire sentence rather than assigning a theological meaning to one English translation.

6. Thanatos — θάνατος

The Greek word **thanatos** means **death**.

It can refer to physical death, but the New Testament also uses the language of death metaphorically and spiritually.

Paul says:

“You were dead in trespasses and sins.”
— Ephesians 2:1

The people Paul addresses were physically alive.

Therefore, their “death” was not simply biological death.

It describes a condition of **spiritual separation and alienation from God**.

This gives us an important biblical distinction:

Physical death

The end of earthly bodily life.

Spiritual death

A condition of separation from God because of sin.

Thus a person can be:

physically alive but spiritually dead.

7. The Second Death — Δεύτερος Θάνατος

The expression “**second death**” appears in Revelation.

Greek:

δεύτερος θάνατος — deuterios thanatos

Literally:

second death

Revelation 20:14 gives the definition:

“This is the second death, the lake of fire.”

Revelation 21:8 uses the same expression in connection with final judgment.

This is an important distinction because the biblical text does not simply say:

Sheol = Hades = Gehenna = lake of fire.

Instead, Revelation introduces the specific expression:

Second Death = Lake of Fire

This is language concerning **final judgment**.

8. A Comparison of the Major Terms

Term	Language	Basic meaning	Important observation
Nephesh	Hebrew	Soul, life, person, self	Broader than “immortal soul”
Psychē	Greek	Soul, life, self, person	Meaning depends on context
Sheol	Hebrew	Realm/condition of the dead	Not automatically final hell
Hades	Greek	Realm of the dead	Closely related to Sheol
Gehenna	Greek	Term associated with judgment	Used especially in Jesus' warnings
Thanatos	Greek	Death	Can describe physical or spiritual death
Second Death	Greek	Final death/judgment	Revelation identifies it with the lake of fire

9. Spiritual Death and Final Death Are Not Necessarily the Same

The biblical terminology allows us to distinguish between **spiritual death** and the **second death**.

Spiritual death

A person is separated from God through sin while still physically alive.

Ephesians 2:1

Physical death

The person's earthly bodily life ends.

Genesis 3:19

Hades/Sheol

Scripture uses these terms in connection with the realm or condition of the dead.

Psalms 16:10; Acts 2:27

Final judgment

Human beings are accountable before God.

Hebrews 9:27

Second death

Revelation describes the lake of fire as the second death.

Revelation 20:14; 21:8

Therefore, these concepts should not be collapsed into one word.

10. Does *Nephesh* or *Psychē* Mean “Immortal Soul”?

This is perhaps the most important question for a theology of the soul.

It would be too simplistic to say:

“The Hebrew word *nephesh* means an immortal soul.”

The word does not carry that entire theological proposition by itself.

Likewise:

“The Greek word *psychē* means an immortal soul.”

This also goes beyond the basic lexical meaning of the word.

The doctrine of immortality must therefore be established from the **whole biblical teaching**, rather than from the definition of one word.

Paul says:

“This mortal must put on immortality.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:53

And 1 Timothy 6:16 speaks of God as the one:

“who alone has immortality.”

These passages must be considered alongside Matthew 10:28 and the other passages concerning the soul.

11. A Biblical Progression

When the vocabulary is carefully distinguished, we can formulate a useful conceptual progression:

Sin

↓

Spiritual death

↓

Corruption of the person

↓

Physical death

↓

Sheol / Hades

↓

Resurrection

↓

Judgment

↓

Final judgment

↓

Second Death / Lake of Fire

This framework prevents several different biblical concepts from being treated as though they were one thing.

Conclusion

The words **nephesh**, **psychē**, **Sheol**, **Hades**, **Gehenna**, **thanatos**, and **second death** each contribute something different to the biblical understanding of humanity, death, sin, and judgment.

The most important lesson from the word study is this:

We should not allow the English word “hell” to erase the distinctions present in the Hebrew and Greek Scriptures.

Sheol and **Hades** are associated with the realm of the dead.

Gehenna is used in Jesus' teaching concerning judgment.

Thanatos means death and can be used in a spiritual sense.

The **second death** is explicitly identified in Revelation with the **lake of fire**.

Likewise, **nephesh** and **psychē** can mean soul, life, person, or self depending upon context. They should not automatically be defined as “immortal soul.”

A serious biblical theology of the soul therefore requires more than translating words. It requires examining **how each word is used throughout Scripture and how the passages relate to one another**.

[The next stage of this study is especially important: examining ἀπόλλυμι (*apollymi*, **destroy/perish**), αἰών (*aiōn*, **age**), αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*, **age-long**), κόλασις (*kolasis*, **punishment**), and “**Long Age fire**.” These words are central to determining what Scripture means by the **punishment, destruction, and duration of the final judgment**.]

[**Already examined the words ἀπόλλυμι (*apollymi*, destroy/perish), αἰών (*aiōn*, age), αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*, age-long), κόλασις (*kolasis*, punishment), and “Long Age fire.” in above written both research papers]**